dream I will see in real life. But the two, Burnley and Lord's, do blend in the imagination this way, by the quirk of uneven footing, if nothing else.

I spend every day, when I am not at the cricket club or at school, bowling a ball at my garage door. Again and again, I run in and bowl the scuffed and chewed tennis ball. Each time I deliver it, I look back up, losing line of sight of it for a second and catch it hurtling towards the batter-less garage door. *Just do something*, I beg of it. *Spin or swing. Do something magical*.

It does nothing. And yet I still run in, over and over. In the Burnley teams, neither being the biggest nor the most powerful, incredibly slight and wiry by comparison to everyone else, I don't really stand out as a batter or a bowler. I don't know which I am, how I best contribute to anything meaningful. My cousin plays with me and says, give me the strike and I'll hit sixes. I do what he says. I do, though, start to use fielding as a kind of asset. The game seems like it allows for anyone to pop up at any given moment and be a hero, and I search for that myself. I know, from the football tournament, that I am capable of small moments of strange transcendence, occasionally doing something special for no other reason than the constant trying. Once, while playing for the third team, I fly through the air and take a catch, an image of Paul Collingwood in a Test match some years later, plucking the ball while suspended in mid-air, unsure where it came from. For me, every ball is a new beginning, a moment that a catch might sail to my right, or a chance to bowl that delivery I'd been searching for, or for the ball to be so sweetly struck that my gifts as a batter suddenly fall out of the sky and into my lap. Another time, during my innings of 49 not out opening the batting, I search for that for 50 overs. It never comes and I walk back into the dressing room, past the purple stairs to a sea of scowls from teammates for dragging the run rate into disrepute.

I am grateful for Burnley Cricket Club, though, because that's where my friends are. School does not offer the friendships that Burnley CC does. My parents encourage me to be there as much as I want to be, because it makes me happy. I begin to realise, just from spending time at the club, amongst so many different age ranges, that I tend to be a completely different person around different people. My character, the way I behave, the things that fall out of my mouth, can vary wildly depending on the environment I'm in.